period of his chairmanship from 1995–2012 was one of spectacular growth. The combination of Ratan and Ramadorai, and later Ratan and Chandrasekaran, worked well for the company. From the year it was listed and nine years on, during which Ratan was at the helm for all but three months, TCS's income grew more than eight times as did the NPAT, which stood at Rs 13,917.31 crore.

As Azim Premji, a doyen of the Indian IT industry, says, 'TCS has been a terrific company; it has always been an honourable competitor, the kind that pushes oneself to do better. As Indians we should all share the pride of its success. Ratan has backed TCS completely and has played a key role in its remarkably strong and stable leadership culture, which has been crucial to its success.'

A New Arena: Tata Advanced Systems Limited

For Ratan, most business opportunities have their origins in social demands. It is all about fulfilling and sustaining a social goal through a business enterprise. This was the motivation that led to the creation of the Tata Advanced Systems Limited (TASL). Ratan wanted to build an organization that would fill the gaps in India's defence production capability. India used to import around 70 per cent of the equipment needed for its defence. This deprived the country of a huge amount of revenue and millions of employment opportunities.

It was also estimated, based on the economic growth projected by the Twelfth Finance Commission, that during the period 2010–15, nearly $50 billion would be spent by India on arms imports. More importantly, this dependence on imports was compromising the nation's sovereignty because of the several denial regimes that are usually put in place by arms-exporting nations.

Ratan was aware of the poor state of India's defence industry. He had been exposed to it when he had served as a board member of Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) for about three years, says Sukaran Singh, MD and CEO of TASL. 'Ratan Tata understood India's strategic vulnerability,' he adds.

TASL was Ratan's contribution to both assist in safeguarding India's sovereignty and strengthening its military capability. With these objectives, the company was created in 2007 as a wholly owned subsidiary of Tata